

# Jimmy Lee 李兆康

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## ACADEMIC POSITIONS

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### Postdoctoral Fellow in Economics

Global Poverty Research Lab, Northwestern University

Sept 2024 – Aug 2026

### Visiting Scholar

Center for International Development, Harvard University

Jan 2025 – June 2026

## OTHER EMPLOYMENT

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### AI Trainer – Economics Expert (Flex time), SpaceXAI

Apr 2026 – Present

## RESEARCH FIELDS

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### Development Economics, Program Evaluation and Scaling

*Focus—Synergies between Agriculture, Rural Education, and Digital Technologies*

### Family Economics, Organizational Economics

*Focus—Intergenerational Dynamics in Rural Household and Community Decision Making*

### Behavioral Economics with applications in program evaluation, agriculture, and education

*Focus—Modeling how agents jointly choose how much weight to place on mental model(s) alternative to a default—possibly several at once—and how much effort to invest in acquiring information about a new situation, under neural capacity constraints*

*With implications for designing interventions that overcome preconceptions and stimulate curiosity, and for measuring beliefs under (possibly) multiple priors*

## EDUCATION

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**Ph.D., Economics**, Northwestern University

2024

**M.Phil., Economics**, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

2017

**B.SSc., Economics**, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

2015

## JOB MARKET PAPER

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### “Miscategorization as an Information Friction: Activating School-Based Agricultural Extension in Liberia with Parental Engagement”

*(Funded by AFD Fund for Innovation in Development, USAID-DIV, Wellspring Foundation, and FAO)*

Schools in developing countries often have weak ties with parents. This paper studies whether development program success hinges on strengthening these ties. In a three-year Liberian experiment across 197 schools, I evaluate school-based agricultural extension (SBAE) against control, cross-randomizing whether to engage parents via promotional videos and field days. SBAE improves targeted outcomes only when paired with engagement: students’ households adopt 26–53% more agricultural techniques, dropouts fall 4–5 percentage points per year, and absenteeism falls 28%. The program is more cost-effective than most extension programs in Africa and over twice as cost-effective as conditional cash transfers in raising attendance. Without it, SBAE’s diffusion mechanisms via school demonstration farms, home projects, and intra-household communication stay muted—technology adoption effects vanish, absenteeism rises 31%, and parents reduce school visits below control. Parents’ information avoidance, plus reversed effects under engagement, challenges standard Bayesian learning. I attribute these patterns to parents conflating SBAE with a discredited school-garden preconception.

## OTHER PAPERS

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### “Communicating Parents’ Beliefs to Students as a Pivotal Component of Parental Engagement: Evidence from School-Based Agricultural Extension in Liberia”

*(Funded by NSF, Weiss Fund, Global Poverty Research Lab, and the Buffett Institute for Global Affairs)*

When school programs require students to make changes on household farms, is informing parents about the program sufficient, or is further signaling their support to students needed? In a randomized evaluation of school-based agricultural extension (SBAE) across 197 Liberian schools, where students take school farm training into a home farming project, I design a nudge that follows a promotional video shown to parents, revealing to students their parents' optimism about their farm-management skills. Two years later, SBAE improves students' livelihoods and schooling only with the nudge: income rises 63%, on-time school fee payment 43–47%, and cost-effectiveness for attendance doubles. Farm interactions unique to the targeted parent-student pair pinpoint the mechanism: even where engaged parents adopt promoted techniques, third-party communication is pivotal in shifting students away from subsistence farming.

## WORK IN PROGRESS

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### *Theory*

1. **“Catalyzing Technology Diffusion in Africa through School-Based Agricultural Extension”**  
(joint with Chris Udry)
2. **“Default Mental Model, Alternative(s) Activation, and Information Acquisition under Neural Capacity Constraints: Theory and Belief Measurements”**
3. **“Directed Technical Change under Data-Driven Farming Advice: An Empirical Framework”**  
(grant from Weiss Fund; piloted survey method; planning RCT)

*Ongoing Randomized Experiments* (scaling of SBAE across Liberia, Côte d'Ivoire, and Kenya in 2026–35)

4. **“Learning to Learn: Synergizing Inquiry-based Science and Agricultural Transformation”**  
(joint with Vesall Nourani, Harvard GSE; scheduled RCT within the scaling of SBAE in 2026–29)
5. **“Parental Engagement in School-based Agricultural Extension: Testing Mechanisms at Scale”**  
(piloted interventions in 2025–26)
6. **“Parental Engagement and the Use of Unconditional Cash Transfers”**

## INVITED PRESENTATIONS

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### *During postdoctoral studies:*

National Chung Cheng University; NYU Africa House—Center for Technology, Economics, and Development (CTED); Mohammed VI Polytechnic University (UM6P); Tel Aviv University; Oklahoma State University; Harvard Graduate School of Education; Harvard Center for International Development; Africa Food Systems Forum 2024

### *During PhD:*

Meeting of the Society of Economics of the Household (SEHO); J-PAL—Middle East and North Africa (MENA); CGIAR—Standing Panel on Impact Assessment (SPIA); International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI); University of Glasgow; National Graduate Institute for Policy Studies (GRIPS, Tokyo); Development Day 2023

## GRANTS AND AWARDS

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*Total program evaluation and academic research grants secured for SBAE in Liberia: \$4.2 million*

### **Program Evaluation Grants**

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|------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| AFD Fund for Innovation in Development (\$1.2 mil; co-PI)        | 2025 |
| J-PAL Learning for All Initiative: Scaling Award (\$222K; co-PI) | 2024 |
| USAID Development Innovation Ventures (\$395K; co-PI)            | 2022 |
| Wellspring Foundation (\$192K; co-PI)                            | 2022 |
| AFD Fund for Innovation in Development (\$1.2 mil; co-PI)        | 2021 |
| Food and Agriculture Organization (\$68K; co-PI)                 | 2021 |

### **Academic Research Awards**

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|---------------------------------------------------|------|
| J-PAL Learning for All Initiative (\$400K; co-PI) | 2025 |
| Weiss Fund (\$5K; Lead PI)                        | 2022 |
| National Science Foundation (\$451K; co-PI)       | 2020 |

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|------------------------------------------------------|------|
| Weiss Fund (\$29K; Lead PI)                          | 2020 |
| Global Poverty Research Lab (\$19K; Lead PI)         | 2019 |
| Buffett Institute for Global Affairs (\$5K; Lead PI) | 2019 |

## TEACHING

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**Teaching Assistant**, Northwestern University

Introduction to Microeconomics, Introduction to Macroeconomics, Intermediate Microeconomics II, Intermediate Macroeconomics, International Trade, Economics of Nonprofit Organizations

## LANGUAGES AND SKILLS

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**Citizenship:** Hong Kong Special Administrative Region, China

**Languages:** English (fluent), French (intermediate), Mandarin (fluent), Cantonese (native)

**Programming:** Stata, R, Matlab, Python, ArcGIS, SurveyCTO

## REFERENCES

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### **Professor Christopher Udry (Chair)**

Department of Economics  
Northwestern University  
2211 Campus Drive, Evanston, IL 60208  
(+1) 847-491-8216  
[christopher.udry@northwestern.edu](mailto:christopher.udry@northwestern.edu)

### **Professor Lori Beaman**

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### **Professor Dean Karlan**

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### **Professor Vesall Nourani**

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